



Newgrange

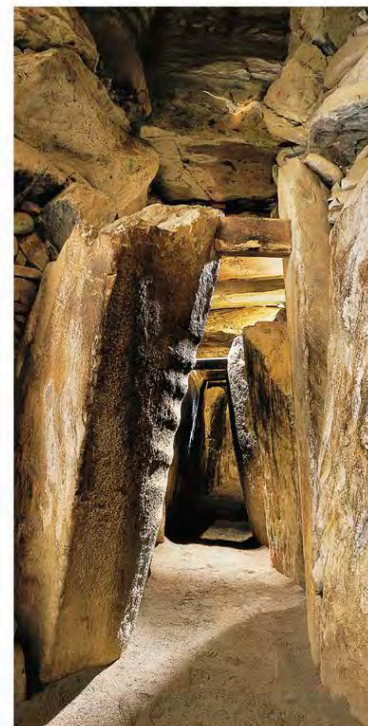
A circular tomb that lights up on the morning of the winter solstice



Older than the pyramids of Egypt or Stonehenge (see p.95) in England, the grand passage tomb of Newgrange in the east of Ireland was probably built in around 3200 BCE. The tomb consists of a large circular mound measuring 262 ft (80 m) in diameter, built up with alternating layers of earth and stones to a height of 36 ft (11 m). The mound has a retaining wall at the front, mostly of white quartz cobblestones, and is ringed by elaborately carved kerbstones and an

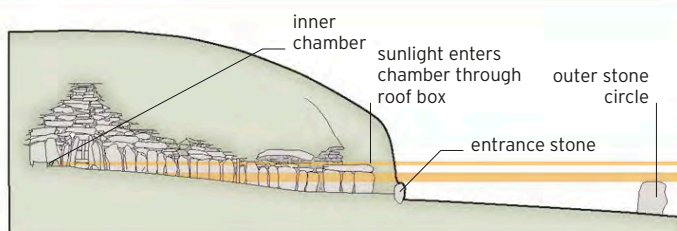
outer stone circle. The 62-ft- (19-m-) long chambered passage, entered from the southeast, runs about one-third of the way into the center. At the end of the passage is a large inner chamber with a high, corbeled vault roof off which are three smaller chambers.

Quite what purpose this tomb served is still unclear; it most likely had a religious purpose, perhaps linked to the worship of the Sun. Irish mythology suggested it was home to the gods, and its power still impresses today.



SOLSTICE ALIGNMENT

At sunrise on the winter solstice, sunlight shines directly down through the passage onto the wall carvings in the inner chamber, notably the *triskelion*, or triple spiral, on the front wall. The illumination lasts for about 17 minutes. Today, the event attracts many visitors; lucky witnesses of the illumination are chosen by lottery.



△ MEGALITHIC TOMB

Most of the 547 slabs of stone in the inner passage and chambers and those that form the outer kerbstones are graywacke, a type of sandstone defined by its hardness and dark color.